

An aerial photograph of a beach and city skyline. The beach is wide and sandy, with many people walking and playing. The ocean is on the right, with waves breaking. In the background, a dense city skyline is visible, featuring several tall skyscrapers, including a prominent one with a blue facade. The sky is clear and blue.

CITY RELOCATION GUIDE · AUSTRALIA

Gold Coast

Where you would work, where you would live, and what an ordinary week looks like in Gold Coast.

Ethicare Resourcing

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ethicareresourcing.com

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This guide is free, and so is everything in it. Every chapter here is also on the website, where it is kept up to date — so if you are reading this some months after downloading it, check the site for anything that looks time-sensitive. Fees, tax rates and immigration settings change without much notice.

We don't print these. A PDF costs nothing to send and nothing to ship, which felt like the right answer for a company that spends its days moving people around the world.

Welcome to the Gold Coast

Gold Coast Guide · Chapter 1 of 9

The Gold Coast is the city most people think they already know from a postcard, and then discover has grown into Australia's sixth-largest — with a hospital campus to match. Fifty-seven kilometres of surf beach, a rainforest hinterland twenty minutes inland, and a health precinct that's become one of the country's genuine growth stories. Here's the city in nine numbers, then six things nobody mentions until you've moved.

A beach city that grew into itself

Around 700,000 people live along a single, near-continuous strip of coastline between Southport and the New South Wales border at Coolangatta — Australia's sixth-largest city, and still one of its fastest-growing. It's an hour south of Brisbane by road or rail, close enough to feel connected, far enough to feel like its own place entirely.

For clinicians the pitch has changed in the last decade: the tertiary teaching hospital at Southport is one of the largest in the country, built alongside a health and knowledge precinct that's still expanding. The whole coast is classed as regional for skilled migration, opening pathways the big capitals don't offer.

The honest costs: a housing market that's grown up fast and isn't the bargain it once was, a light-rail network that covers the coast but not the hinterland, and a professional community still working out its own identity between "Brisbane's beach suburb" and a genuine city in its own right. This guide prices all three plainly.

Who wrote this

We're a healthcare recruitment company, so we have an interest — but this guide isn't a pitch. There's nothing in it asking you to register, and no visa advice.

The Gold Coast rewards people who want a genuine outdoor lifestyle alongside real career growth, and the honest answer to "is this still a beach suburb or a real city" matters more here than almost anywhere.

Where we think it's the wrong fit, we say so.

The city, in nine numbers

~700,000

People along the coast — Australia's sixth-largest city, and still growing fast.

57 km

Of surf beach, from Southport to Coolangatta on the New South Wales border.

1 hr

To Brisbane by road or rail — close enough for a specialist appointment or a night out.

2018

The year the Gold Coast hosted the Commonwealth Games, a turning point for the city's infrastructure and profile.

2

Universities call the coast home — Griffith and Bond.

Regional

The whole coast's classification for skilled migration purposes.

1

Full tertiary teaching hospital, one of the largest in the country.

G:link

The light rail that runs the length of the coastal strip.

20 min

Inland to rainforest, waterfalls and cooler air.

Six things you only learn once you're here

The beach is the commute, for some

Plenty of suburbs put the sand within walking distance — genuinely rare for a city this size.

It's a university town twice over

Griffith and Bond give the coast a younger energy than the postcard suggests.

The hinterland is twenty minutes away, not two hours

Rainforest, waterfalls and cooler air are a genuine weeknight option, not just a weekend trip.

Brisbane is closer than it looks

The train makes a specialist appointment or a night out a realistic hour, not an expedition.

It's still figuring out its own identity

Some see it as Brisbane's beach suburb. Locals will tell you, firmly, that it isn't.

The growth is real, and it shows

Cranes on the skyline are a permanent feature; the city you move to won't look quite the same in five years.

A note on Country

The Gold Coast sits on the land of the Yugambeh-speaking peoples, including the Kombumerri clan group.

Acknowledgement of Country opens meetings and events across the region, and taking time to learn whose Country you're on is genuinely appreciated here.

How to read this guide

Nine chapters, all about the Gold Coast specifically. Anything true of Australia generally — Medicare, visas, Ahpra registration, tax, superannuation, schools — lives once in **Moving to Australia**, so you only read it once.

If you read nothing else, read [Why the Gold Coast](#) for the full case — and what we'd ask you to weigh, and [Healthcare on the Gold Coast](#), because the system here is younger and growing faster than anywhere else in this collection.

Why the Gold Coast

Gold Coast Guide · Chapter 2 of 9

The Gold Coast offers a beach-and-hinterland lifestyle very few cities can match, with a young health system growing fast into its population. Here's the case, and what we'd ask you to weigh.

What you're trading up for

- A beach-and-hinterland lifestyle unmatched by any comparable-sized Australian city.
- A full tertiary teaching hospital and a health precinct still expanding.
- Regional migration status for the whole coast.
- Light rail along the strip and an easy hour to Brisbane by train.
- A long, warm season and a mild, sunny winter.
- University-town energy from Griffith and Bond.
- A lower cost of entry than Sydney or Melbourne — still true, even as it closes.

Forty kilometres of beach, with a city attached

What it actually asks of you

The honest costs

Rapid growth means traffic and construction are a visible, ongoing feature of daily life.

The professional community and specialist bench are smaller than Brisbane's, so some complex tertiary cases still go north.

The city's identity is genuinely still forming — don't expect an established, Melbourne-style inner-city culture.

Summer brings real humidity and the occasional ex-tropical weather system.

A tourism economy means some northern-strip suburbs feel transient, especially around Surfers Paradise.

Light rail doesn't reach the hinterland or the western growth corridor, so a car still matters for a lot of daily life.

A typical week

A swim or a walk on the beach before work is a genuine routine for a lot of people here, not an aspiration.

Weekends split between the coast and the hinterland — a market, a surf, then a drive up to Tamborine or

Springbrook for lunch and cooler air. The pace is more Queensland than Sydney: outdoor, unhurried, and

built around the weather rather than around it being an obstacle.

When we'd point you to Brisbane instead

You want the widest possible specialist bench

Some complex tertiary care is still better served in Brisbane, Sydney or Melbourne.

You want an established city, not a forming one

The Gold Coast is still working out its identity; if you want inner-city history and permanence, it isn't there yet.

You want a strong four-season climate

Subtropical means warm most of the year — wonderful for some, monotonous for others.

You want to be car-free everywhere

Light rail covers the strip well; the hinterland and outer suburbs still need a car.

The tourist intensity isn't for you

The northern strip in peak season, and Schoolies week each November, aren't to everyone's taste — the southern coast is much quieter.

Where we'd steer you instead

If you want a tertiary centre and rather less tourism churn, **Brisbane** is an hour north.

If the reef and a quieter regional city appeal more than the strip, **Bundaberg** is a different Queensland altogether.

If you are weighing the state as a whole, the **Queensland brief** covers how much it changes between the border and the tropics.

In our experience

The Gold Coast suits clinicians who want to grow with a system rather than inherit one — the units are young, the population curve is steep, and that means opportunity arrives early. The lifestyle isn't the consolation prize; it's the plan.

“

The Gold Coast doesn't ask you to choose between career and lifestyle. It hands you both while the city grows into them.

The Gold Coast at a glance

Gold Coast Guide · Chapter 3 of 9

The Gold Coast is a single coastal strip with a rainforest spine behind it, built fast and still building. Here's the geography, the history and the people, in brief.

A subtropical coast, most of the year

Four seasons exist here more as a formality than a felt experience — the real distinction is between a long, warm, sometimes-humid stretch and a shorter, mild, drier one that draws the crowds.

Summer
Dec – Feb
21–29°
Hot, humid, storm season
Autumn
Mar – May
17–25°
Warm, drier, easing off
Winter
Jun – Aug
10–21°
Mild, sunny, the dry season
Spring
Sep – Nov
16–25°
Warming, humidity building

Winter is the coast's best-kept secret: mild days, low humidity and clear skies, which is exactly why the tourist season peaks then rather than in summer. Summer brings the heat, the humidity and the storms — and, some years, an ex-tropical system to plan around.

A short history

Before European settlement

Yugambah Country

The Gold Coast sits on the land of the Yugambah-speaking peoples, including the Kombumerri clan group.

1800s

Timber and sugar

Early settlement centres on timber-getting and sugar cane along the coastal strip.

Mid-20th century

The tourism boom

Post-war Australia discovers the coast; the “Gold Coast” name and the high-rise skyline both take shape.

2018

The Commonwealth Games

A turning point for infrastructure and international profile, including the light rail's expansion.

Today

Australia's sixth-largest city

Still one of the country's fastest-growing, with a health and knowledge precinct to match its population.

Who lives here

A young, growing population

One of the country's fastest-growing cities, skewed toward working-age arrivals and young families.

A magnet for interstate movers

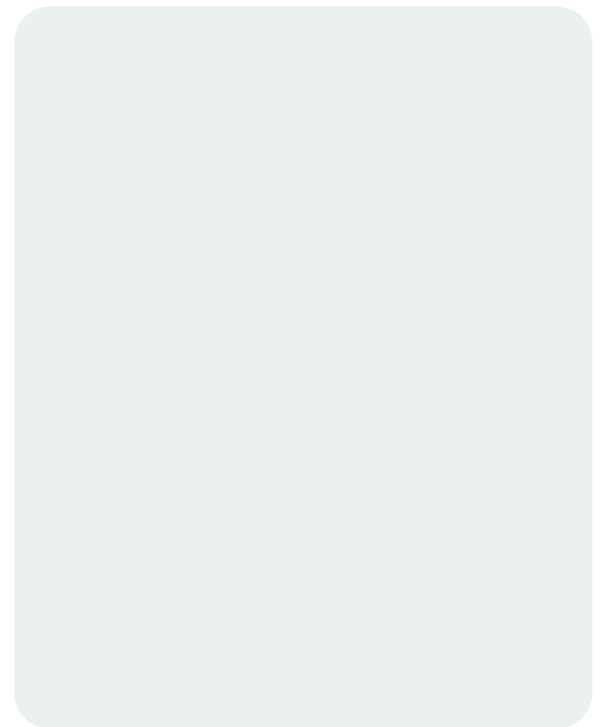
A steady stream of Australians relocate here from Sydney and Melbourne, drawn by lifestyle and cost.

Two university communities

Griffith and Bond bring a genuine student population and academic health precinct.

Tourism, health and construction

The coast's three biggest employers, and the clearest sign of a city still being built.



Where Gold Coast sits, with the straight-line distance to Brisbane

Healthcare on the Gold Coast

Gold Coast Guide · Chapter 4 of 9



Healthcare on the Gold Coast has grown as fast as everything else here: from a modest regional service to a full tertiary teaching campus in barely a decade, with the system still catching up to the population around it.

The system

The tertiary teaching hospital

A full tertiary teaching hospital at Southport, one of the largest in the country, paired with Griffith University's health precinct.

A second public campus

A public-private campus serving the southern coast, easing pressure on the tertiary centre.

A large private sector

Several major private hospitals along the strip add real depth and choice to the system.

A young, expanding system

Still building its specialist bench — some highly specialised tertiary care is referred to Brisbane.

A note on names

We don't name hospitals, trusts or private providers as places of work anywhere on this site — a named employer implies a relationship, and the post and the package get confirmed with you directly.

Where a public body is named on this page, it is there as a **reference point** for how the system is organised. It is not an employer reference, and it does not imply we recruit for it.

What makes practice here different

Rapid growth means genuine opportunity and responsibility earlier than in a more established system, and the Griffith University partnership brings a teaching-hospital culture from day one.

A SYSTEM STILL BEING BUILT

The Gold Coast went from a modest regional service to a full tertiary teaching campus in barely a decade. Everything distinctive about working here – good and less good – comes from that pace.

WHAT THE GROWTH GIVES YOU

Responsibility earlier

New departments need senior people. Roles open here that a settled system would fill from within, and they open sooner in a career.

A teaching culture from day one

The Griffith University health precinct sits alongside the hospital, so students, trainees and research are part of the ordinary week.

Scale without the eastern-capital price

One of the country's largest hospitals, in a city where you can still live near the beach.

A department you help shape

Services still forming are services you can influence – rare in a mature tertiary hospital.

WHAT IT ASKS OF YOU

A bench still catching up

The specialist bench is younger than the population it serves. Ask how many consultants sit alongside you in your specialty, not how many are in the hospital.

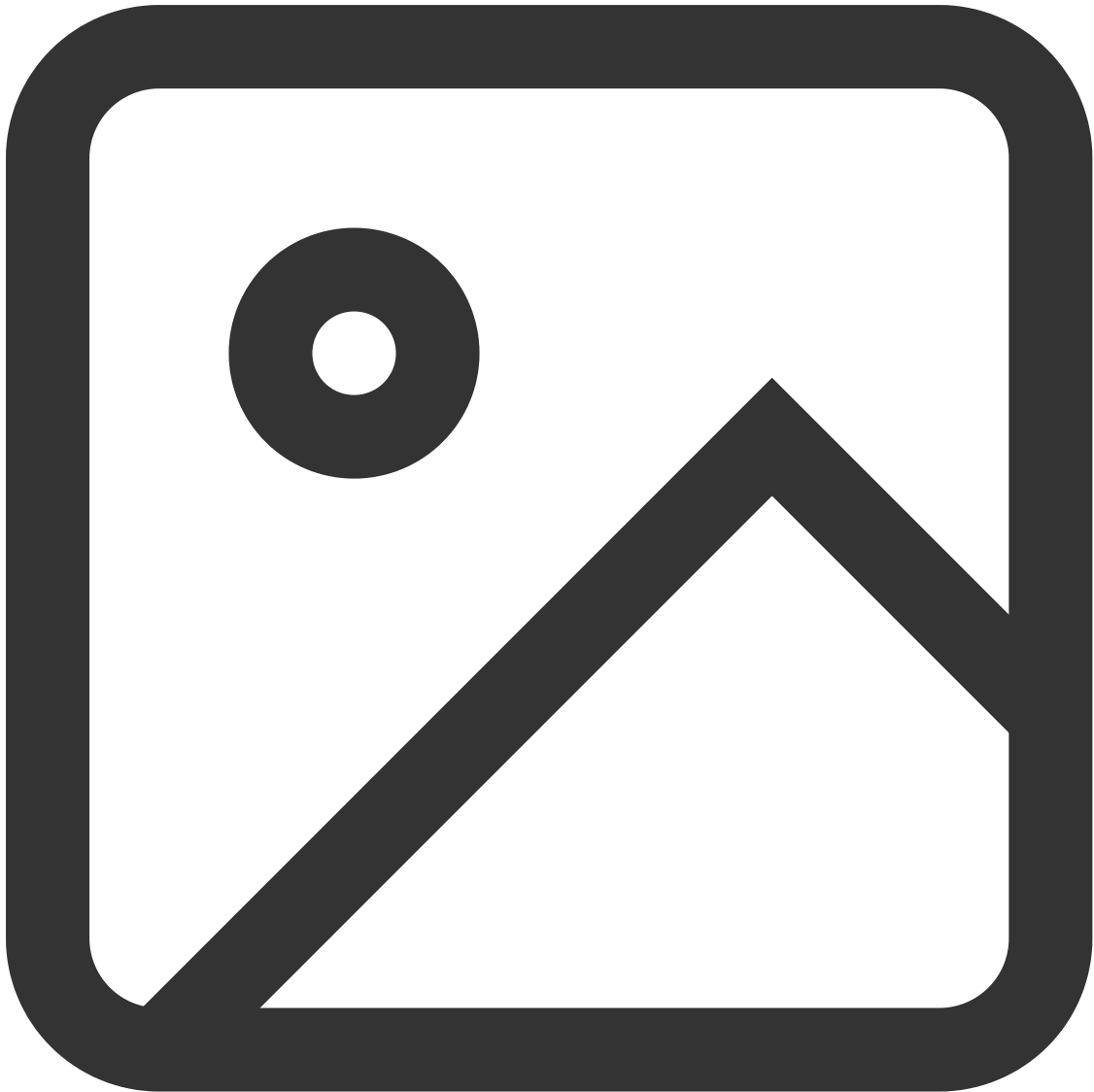
A short referral list to Brisbane

A small number of highly specialised tertiary cases go north. Worth understanding which ones touch your work before you start.

Comfort with change

Rosters, structures and reporting lines move faster in a growing service than a settled one.

If your field is very narrow, tell us early and we will be straight with you about whether the bench here is wide enough yet.



A clinical precinct

Photography to come

What to ask at interview

What's the growth trajectory of the specific department you'd join?

Which cases get referred to Brisbane, and how is that handled day to day?

What teaching and research involvement comes with the Griffith University partnership?

What CPD time and funding is provided?

How established is the specialist bench in your specialty specifically?

The takeaway

The Gold Coast offers real, fast-moving opportunity in a system still building itself out — and it asks you to be comfortable with that pace of change. Ask specifically what's still maturing in your specialty, and you'll walk in with realistic expectations.

Where clinicians live

Gold Coast Guide · Chapter 5 of 9



Where you live on the Gold Coast shapes your day more than almost anywhere else in this collection — the coast runs from high-rise beachfront to canal estates to hinterland acreage, often within a few kilometres of each other.

Waterfront canal homes — a Gold Coast signature.

The Gold Coast at a glance, by area

Area	Best for	Worth knowing
Surfers Paradise & Broadbeach High-rise, the coast's commercial heart	Singles & couples, walk to everything	Vibrant but touristy, especially in peak season
Burleigh, Miami & Mermaid Beach Trendy, beachy, cafe culture	Professionals & young families	Popular and priced accordingly
Canal estates Sorrento, Mermaid Waters, Broadbeach Waters	Families who want water frontage	A premium for the waterfront, but genuinely part of daily life
Robina & Varsity Lakes Planned suburbs near Bond University & the southern hospital campus	Families, good schools	Purpose-built, less beach-adjacent
Southern beach towns Currumbin, Palm Beach, Coolangatta	A slower pace, close to the airport & NSW border	Further from the tertiary campus; a longer commute north
Hinterland acreage Tamboorine, Springbrook, Currumbin Valley	Space and a cooler climate	Longer commute, a car is essential

Choosing your area, in order

Fix your work site first — the tertiary campus (Southport) and the southern campus sit at opposite ends of the strip.

Check school catchments if you have children; growth-corridor suburbs sometimes have schools still catching up to demand.

Shortlist two or three suburbs and rent short-term in one before committing long-term.

Decide how much you value beach access versus space — the trade-off is real and worth testing before you buy.

A fast-growing market

The Gold Coast's housing market has grown quickly; prices and rents are no longer the bargain they once were relative to Brisbane.

On the open market, expect to apply with ID, references and proof of income, then pay a bond, typically four weeks' rent.

Getting around

Gold Coast Guide · Chapter 6 of 9



The Gold Coast is easier to get around than its sprawl suggests, as long as you understand which parts of it the light rail actually reaches.

Getting around the coast

Driving

Essential for the hinterland and the western growth corridor. The M1 to Brisbane is famously congested on weekends and public holidays.

G:link light rail

Runs the length of the coastal strip and has extended further south over time – useful if you live and work near it.

Heavy rail

Connects the coast to Brisbane in around an hour, making the capital genuinely commutable for some.

Gold Coast Airport

At Coolangatta, with domestic and trans-Tasman flights; Brisbane Airport covers the wider international network.

The G:link light rail along the coastal strip.

HOW FAR EVERYTHING IS FROM THE STRIP

Typical off-peak times from the central coast, to scale against each other. The light rail covers the first row; everything below it needs a car or a train – and the marked row is the one that decides whether Brisbane counts as reachable.

Along the strip

End to end on the G:link, which is why the strip is the one part of the coast you can live in car-free



~20 min

Gold Coast Airport

Closer than most capitals manage – a real advantage for trips home



~30 min

The hinterland

Springbrook, Tamborine and the rainforest – a car, not a tram



~45 min

Brisbane

Rail, not the M1 – the reliable version of this journey



~1 hour

Brisbane Airport

The long-haul option, and the reason the drive north is worth timing



~1 hr 30

Indicative off-peak times. The M1 north is famously congested on weekends and public holidays – the rail line is the reliable version of that journey.

Sophie's tip

If you can live and work near a light rail stop, do – it genuinely changes daily life here. If your role is in the hinterland or the western suburbs, budget for a car as a certainty, not an option, and avoid the M1 on long weekends if you can.

Cost of living

Gold Coast Guide · Chapter 7 of 9



The Gold Coast's cost of living sits between the big southern capitals and the rest of Queensland: no longer the bargain it once was, but still generally ahead of Sydney or Melbourne for the same money.

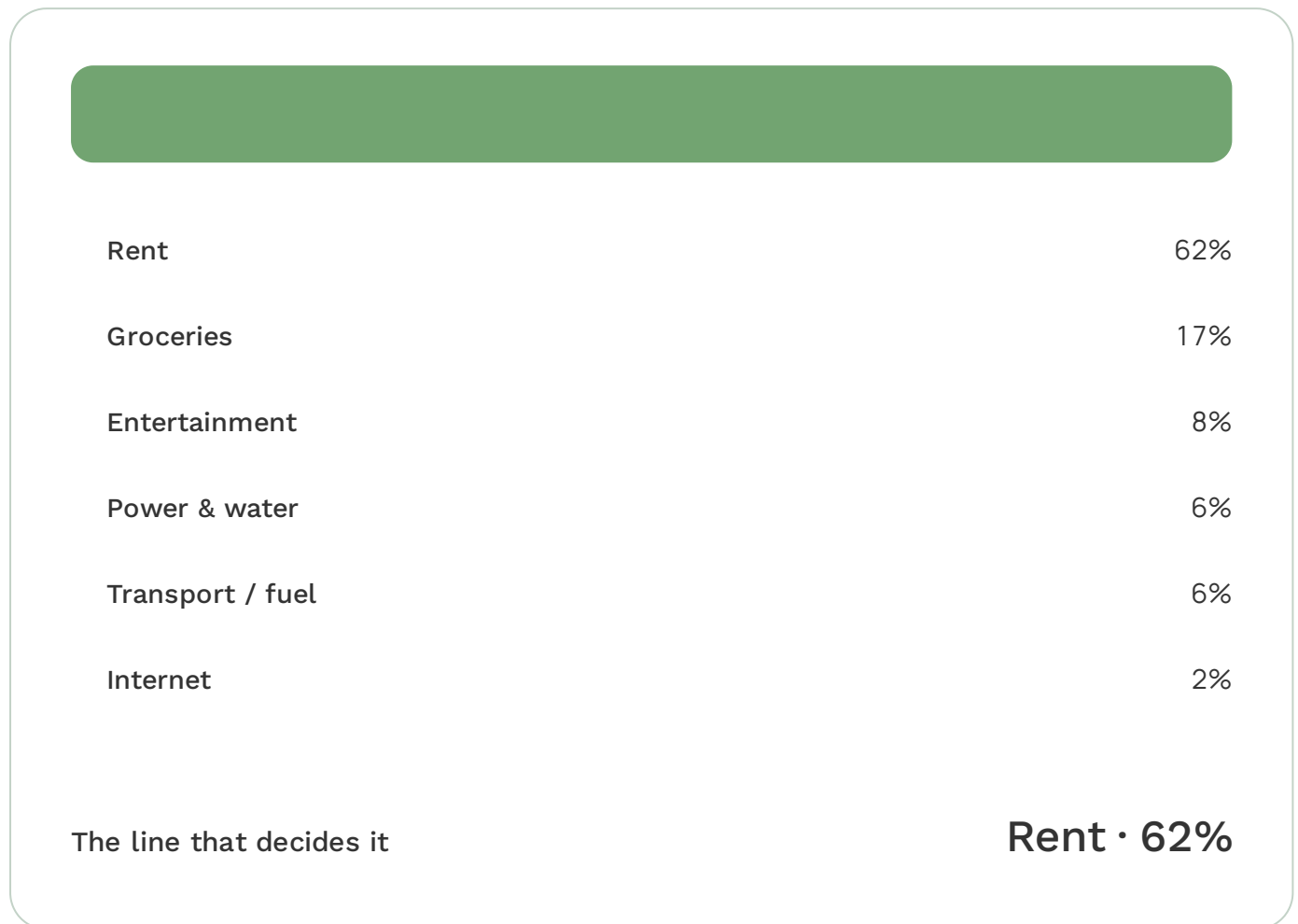
Why there are no prices on this page

We used to print a weekly rent and a monthly budget table here. We have taken them out. A figure that was true when a page was written is misleading a year later, and a candidate who plans a move around a stale number is worse off than one who plans around none.

What does not go stale is the *shape* of a month, and the judgement about which lines will surprise you – which is what the rest of this chapter is for. For today's actual numbers use the calculators at the foot of the page, and use them to compare the Gold Coast against the city you are leaving. That is the only comparison that decides anything.

WHERE A MONTH ACTUALLY GOES

The proportions, for one person on a mid-range budget. Proportions move slowly; prices move every quarter. Rent is over sixty per cent of it – the largest share of any destination in this collection.



That rent share is why the Gold Coast is no longer the bargain it once was – though it still sits ahead of Sydney or Melbourne for the same money. The suburb you choose does most of the work here.

On the payslip

Pay and allowances vary by role, employer and agreement, so we won't quote figures here – ask us directly and we'll talk you through what's realistic for your profession. Our [national living-in-Australia guide](#) covers pay packaging and the wider picture.

Get today's numbers, and compare them to home

These are live and updated continuously, which is why we send you to them rather than competing with them. Put the city you are leaving in the other box.

Numbeo cost-of-living calculator (<https://www.numbeo.com/cost-of-living/>) — the most complete comparison tool, and the one most clinicians already use. Crowd-sourced, so read it as a ballpark rather than a quote.

Expatistan (<https://www.expatistan.com/cost-of-living>) — the same idea with a cleaner side-by-side. Worth running as a sanity check when Numbeo looks off.

Australian Bureau of Statistics (<https://www.abs.gov.au/statistics/economy/price-indexes-and-inflation>) — official, slower, and the one to trust on the direction of travel rather than any single price.

If what you find contradicts the judgement on this page, tell us. We would rather correct the page than defend it.

Food & the everyday

Gold Coast Guide · Chapter 8 of 9



Food on the Gold Coast runs from beachside brunch culture to hinterland farm-gate produce, with the coast's dining scene maturing about as fast as everything else here.

Where the coast eats

Burleigh Heads

The coast's best-known dining strip — breakfast culture, cafes and some of its most-loved restaurants.

Miami Marketta

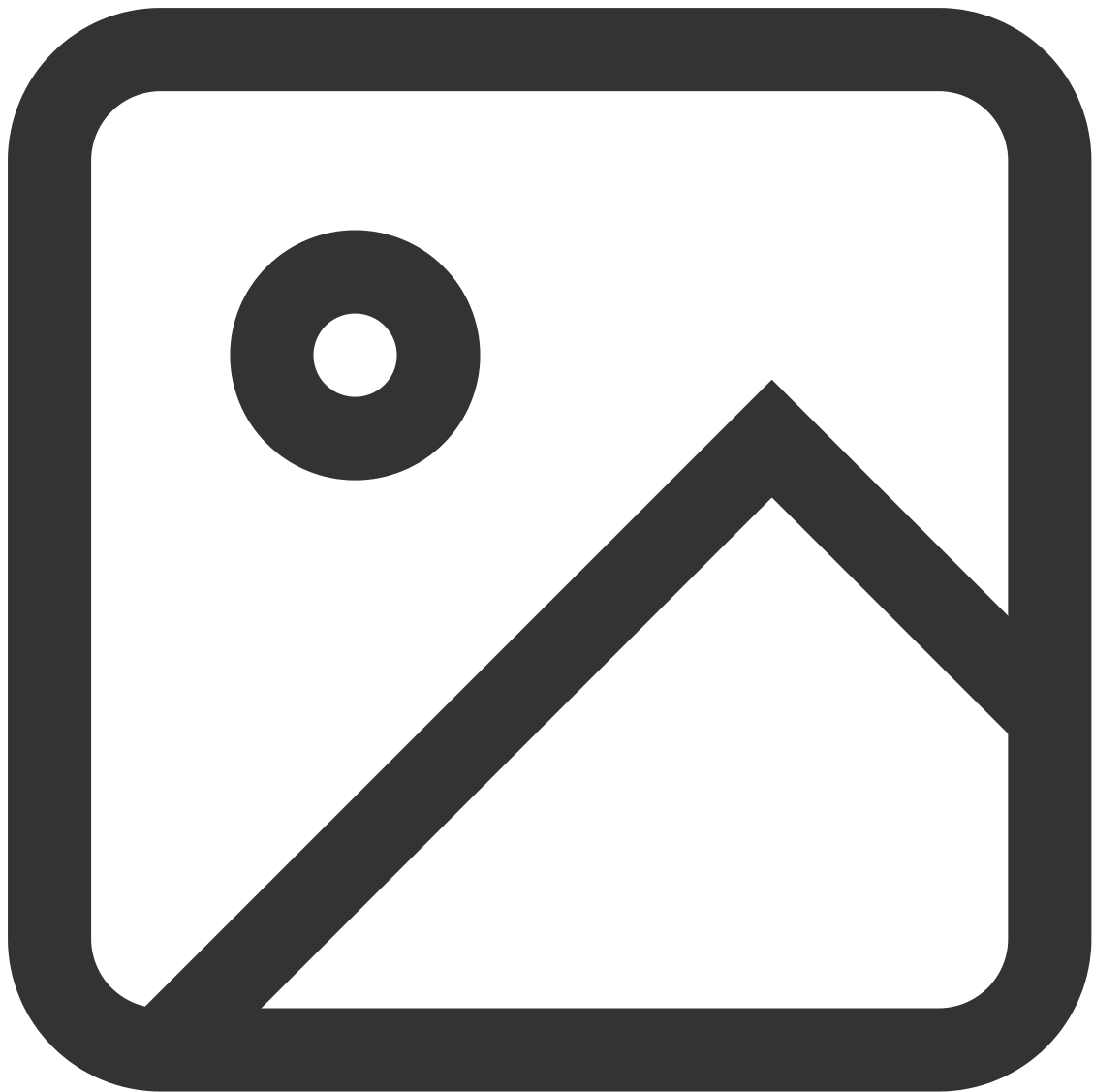
A Friday and Saturday night market with street food stalls and live music, a genuine local institution.

Hinterland farm-gate

Tamborine Mountain's wineries and farm stalls make the drive up the range worth it for more than the view.

Fresh seafood

Local co-ops and fish markets along the coast keep the catch close to the table.



Burleigh Heads or Miami Marketta

Photography to come

Where to shop

Woolworths and Coles cover the full range across the coast; ALDI is the cheapest weekly shop; IGA and independents fill in around the edges, especially in the hinterland. The coast's café and dining scene is a genuine drawcard – casual, outdoor and built around the beach, whatever the day.

The Goldy The informal, affectionate nickname most Australians use for the Gold Coast.

The Strip Surfers Paradise's beachfront core, around Cavill Avenue.

The M1 The Pacific Motorway to Brisbane – and the road everyone complains about on long weekends.

The Hinterland The elevated rainforest country behind the coast – Tamborine, Springbrook, Lamington.

Schoolies The school-leavers' festival held on the coast every November – worth knowing about if you're arranging accommodation that month.

Sophie's tip

Book ahead for Burleigh's better-known cafes on weekends – the coast's food reputation is well and truly out, and the queues prove it.

Hinterland, waterfalls & the weekend

Gold Coast Guide · Chapter 9 of 9

The Gold Coast's best-kept secret isn't the beach — it's what sits twenty minutes inland. Rainforest, waterfalls and cool mountain air, all within a genuine weeknight's reach.

Rainforest on the doorstep

UP THE RANGE, IN DRIVING TIME

To scale against each other. The marked rows are the point of this chapter: two national parks and a mountain village, all close enough to reach after a day shift.

Natural Bridge

A rock arch and glow-worm cave, especially memorable on an evening walk



~40 min

Tamborine Mountain

Villages, wineries and lookouts up the range – a genuine after-work escape



~45 min

Springbrook National Park

Ancient rainforest and waterfalls, including Purling Brook Falls



~45 min

Lamington & O'Reilly's

Rainforest walks and wildlife – a comfortable half-day or full-day trip



~1 hr 30

Indicative driving times. Hinterland roads wind more than GPS estimates suggest, so allow extra – and some falls run better after rain than in a dry spell.

Wildlife in the Gold Coast hinterland is never far from the coast.

A note on logistics

Hinterland roads wind more than GPS estimates suggest – allow extra time. Some waterfalls run better after rain and can slow to a trickle in a dry spell, so it's worth checking conditions before a special trip.

Closer to home

Burleigh Head National Park's headland walk is a genuine after-work option with a beach at either end of it. Currumbin Wildlife Sanctuary puts native wildlife inside the suburbs, and the Southport Broadwater is where a lot of the coast goes to fish, paddle or simply watch the sunset without leaving town.